

The Handyman Plan

The Handyman — Project Plan & Development Approach

A marketplace connecting verified artisans (plumbers, electricians, carpenters, masons, mowers) with people who need their services in Ghana.

Prepared as a working blueprint. This document captures the decisions made so far and lays out a phased build. It is meant to be revised as the project grows.

1. The Concept in One Paragraph

Today, finding a trustworthy plumber or electrician in Ghana happens by word of mouth. The Handyman replaces that with a trusted digital marketplace: verified artisans list their services; users find them by location and problem type; payment happens on the platform with funds held safely until the job is confirmed done; and a review system keeps quality high. The platform earns money two ways — a percentage commission on each completed job, and a subscription fee paid by artisans to stay listed.

2. The Two Users

Service Users — people who need work done. They search, browse verified artisans, book a job, pay into escrow, and review the artisan afterwards.

Service Providers (Artisans) — verified tradespeople. They create a profile, list services and prices, accept job requests, complete work, get paid when the user confirms, and build a reputation through reviews.

A third role, **Admin**, runs the platform: approving verifications, handling disputes, managing subscriptions and payouts.

3. Key Decisions Made So Far

Decision	Choice	Why
First build (MVP)	One trade, one city (e.g. plumbers in Accra)	Easier to recruit and verify a small set; proves the core loop before scaling
Tech approach	One codebase in JavaScript/TypeScript	You learn one language for web + iOS + Android
Web frontend	React	Standard, huge community, reusable with mobile
Mobile app	React Native via Expo	iOS + Android from the same skills
Backend + database	Node.js + Supabase (Postgres, auth, file storage)	One managed service, generous free tier
Payments	Paystack (Mobile Money + cards), built to add Hubtel later	Clean API, supports split payments and MoMo
Payment timing	Escrow — user pays up front, released on confirmation	Protects both sides; prevents non-payment after work is done
Login	Phone number + OTP primary, email optional	Matches how Ghanaians actually identify and pay

4. The Core Loop (What the MVP Must Do)

This single loop is the heart of the platform. Everything else is built around it.

1. A user signs up and describes their problem (or picks a service category).
2. The app shows verified artisans nearby, with ratings and prices.
3. The user requests a booking; the artisan accepts and they agree on a price.
4. The user pays into escrow — the platform holds the money.
5. The artisan does the work.
6. The user confirms completion. The platform releases payment to the artisan, minus the commission.
7. The user leaves a review and rating.

If this loop works smoothly for 20 plumbers and their customers, the business is proven. Everything in Phase 2 and beyond simply makes this loop richer.

5. How Escrow Works (Plain English)

Escrow is what makes the platform trustworthy. Here is the flow:

When a user books a job, they pay the agreed amount through Paystack into the platform’s holding account — not directly to the artisan. The money sits there, “held.” Neither side can touch it. When the job is done and the **user taps “Confirm Completion,”** the platform releases the funds to the artisan’s Mobile Money or bank account, automatically keeping the platform’s commission. If something goes wrong, the money stays held and an admin steps in to resolve the dispute before releasing or refunding.

This protects everyone: the artisan knows the money is real before starting, the user knows the artisan only gets paid when satisfied, and the platform safely earns its cut in the middle.

A note for later: a true “hold and release” escrow may require checking Paystack’s current rules for Ghana, and possibly a partner bank arrangement. The build will start with a workable version (collect, then pay out on confirmation) and tighten the compliance side as the platform grows.

6. Verification — A Human Process, Not a Checkbox

Because artisans enter people’s homes, trust is the product. Verification is an operational workflow that an admin performs before an artisan goes live:

- **Identity:** Ghana Card (national ID) photo and number.
- **Background:** Police report / criminal record check.
- **Residence:** Proof of where they live.
- **Guarantor:** A named guarantor with contact details who vouches for them.
- **Skills evidence:** Photos of past work, certificates where they exist, or a short in-person assessment.

In the app this is just a set of uploaded documents and a status flag: `pending` → `approved` / `rejected`. The real work is the admin reviewing them. Start manual. Automate later only if volume demands it.

7. Reviews, Ratings & Reputation

After every completed job, the user can leave a star rating (1–5), a written comment, and an upvote/downvote. An artisan’s profile shows their average rating, number of jobs completed, and recent reviews. This is what lets good artisans rise and pushes out bad ones — and it is what makes users trust the platform over word of mouth. Reviews should only be possible after a *real, paid, completed* job, so they cannot be faked.

8. How the Platform Makes Money

Commission: A percentage (e.g. 10–15%) is automatically deducted from each completed job before the artisan is paid. Decide the exact rate later; make it a setting, not a hard-coded number.

Subscription: Artisans pay a recurring fee (monthly or yearly) to remain listed and visible. You might offer a free basic tier and a paid tier with more visibility, more job slots, or a “verified pro” badge.

Both should be adjustable settings so you can experiment without rebuilding.

9. Suggested Additional Features (Beyond Your Skeleton)

Things that strengthen the platform, to add as you grow:

- **In-app chat** between user and artisan to discuss the job before booking.
- **Job photos** — user uploads a photo of the problem; artisan sees it before quoting.
- **Live job status** — requested, accepted, on the way, in progress, completed.
- **Emergency / urgent bookings** at a premium rate.
- **Notifications** (SMS + push) for bookings, payments, and reminders.
- **Dispute resolution flow** with admin mediation and partial refunds.
- **Artisan earnings dashboard** showing income, pending payouts, ratings over time.
- **Referral rewards** to grow both sides of the marketplace cheaply.
- **Favourites / re-book** so users can call back an artisan they liked.
- **Multi-language** — English plus Twi/Ga later for wider reach.

10. The Data Model (Plain-English Tables)

These are the core “tables” the database will hold. Each is a list of records.

- **Users** — everyone: name, phone, email, role (user / artisan / admin), location, created date.
- **Artisan Profiles** — links to a user; trade, bio, service area, verification status, subscription status, average rating.
- **Verification Documents** — the uploaded ID, police report, residence proof, guarantor info; status.
- **Services** — what an artisan offers and the price or rate for each.
- **Bookings** — a job: which user, which artisan, the service, location, agreed price, status, timestamps.
- **Payments** — tied to a booking: amount, commission, escrow status (held / released / refunded), Paystack reference.
- **Reviews** — tied to a completed booking: rating, comment, vote.
- **Subscriptions** — artisan, plan, start/end dates, payment status.
- **Messages** (later) — chat between a user and artisan for a booking.

11. Recommended Technology Stack

Layer	Tool	Note
Web app	React	Runs in any browser, mobile-friendly
Mobile app	React Native (Expo)	iOS + Android, one codebase
Backend / database / auth / file storage	Supabase (Postgres)	All-in-one, free tier to start
Payments	Paystack	Mobile Money + cards + split payments
SMS / OTP	Arkesel or Hubtel SMS	Per-message cost — budget for it
Web hosting	Vercel	Free tier, easy deploys
App distribution	Expo / app stores	Build and ship to Play Store first

Everything is JavaScript/TypeScript end to end, so the skills carry across web, mobile, and server.

12. Phased Roadmap

Phase 0 — Foundations. Set up the project, database, and accounts (Supabase, Paystack, SMS). Build sign-up and login with phone + OTP. Define the data model.

Phase 1 — The MVP Core Loop (one trade, one city). Artisan profiles and verification upload; admin approval; service listings; search by location; booking; escrow payment via Paystack; confirm-completion and payout; reviews. *Launch here.*

Phase 2 — Trust & Money Polish. Subscriptions; commission settings; notifications; in-app chat; job photos and live status; artisan earnings dashboard.

Phase 3 — Scale. More trades, more cities; dispute resolution; referrals; favourites; emergency bookings; analytics; multi-

language.

Launch at the end of Phase 1. Do not wait for Phases 2 and 3 — real users will tell you what to build next.

13. Open Questions to Settle Next

These will shape the build and are worth deciding soon:

1. What commission percentage and subscription price will you start with?
 2. Which single trade and city do you want to launch with?
 3. Do you already have artisans willing to join the pilot? (Recruiting them is as important as the code.)
 4. What is your budget for SMS costs, hosting, and the Paystack/business account setup?
 5. Will you register a business entity to open the Paystack merchant account that escrow requires?
 6. Who will do the manual verification reviews at the start — you, or a hire?
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This is a living document. As decisions are made and the build progresses, it should be updated to stay the single source of truth for the project.